

THE CHURCH A BATTLESHIP OR A CRUISESHIP

TEXT: Luke 5:1-11 “And it came to pass, that, as the people pressed upon him to hear the word of God, he stood by the lake of Gennesaret, 2 And saw two ships standing by the lake: but the fishermen were gone out of them, and were washing their nets. 3 And he entered into one of the ships, which was Simon’s, and prayed him that he would thrust out a little from the land. And he sat down, and taught the people out of the ship. 4 Now when he had left speaking, he said unto Simon, **Launch out into the deep, and let down your nets for a draught.** 5 And Simon answering said unto him, Master, we have toiled all the night, and have taken nothing: nevertheless at thy word I will let down the net. 6 And when they had this done, they enclosed a great multitude of fishes: and their net brake. 7 And they beckoned unto their partners, which were in the other ship, that they should come and help them. And they came, and filled both the ships, so that they began to sink. 8 When Simon Peter saw it, he fell down at Jesus’ knees, saying, depart from me; for I am a sinful man, O Lord. 9 For he was astonished, and all that were with him, at the draught of the fishes which they had taken: 10 And so was also James, and John, the sons of Zebedee, which were partners with Simon. And Jesus said unto Simon, **Fear not; from henceforth thou shalt catch men.** 11 And when they had brought their ships to land, they forsook all, and followed him.”

INTRO: I have decided to use as my text for this series of sermons a scripture that I am sure is familiar to all of us who have been around the church for any length of time. In this scripture two factors produce the dynamics of the story; during ministry at the side of this lake Jesus encounters:

- Two ships... I would like to draw a parallel between the ships in our story and the church.

- Fishermen... I would like to draw a parallel between the **fishermen** in this story and those of us who have decided to become a part of Gods **program** on earth.

The two ships and all the fishermen were **fruitless** in their efforts until Jesus became involved. Notice the frustration in the voice of Simon when instructed by Jesus to return to the business of fishing, Luke 5:5 **“And Simon answering said unto him, Master, we have toiled all the night, and have taken nothing...”** These guys were no doubt tired, frustrated, agitated, aggravated, humiliated, not to mention being flat broke! Most church problems could be solved with a fresh catch!

The fishermen in this story have **abandoned** the boats and are **washing** their nets! Luke 5:2 **“Jesus saw two ships standing by the lake: but the fishermen were gone out of them, and were washing *their* nets.”** This fishing business has not turned out to be all that they had imagined it would. All the best laid plans of men will be fruitless until Jesus is on board. The church of this hour is guilty of wearing themselves out on ideas that have absolutely no hope of catching men! We have clean nets and empty boats! Most churches smell sterile because they are! Mediocrity has all but neutered the church!

When Jesus became involved he revealed both the **problem** and the **solution**. Luke 5:4 **“He said unto Simon, **Launch out into the deep, and let down your nets for a draught.**”** Notice Jesus speaks to a question that has not even been asked. He gives advice that has not been requested. Jesus was a preacher not a fisherman. As a novice he is giving advice to professionals. I’m not sure these fishermen were all that eager to get fishing advice from a preacher. Jesus told them they needed to launch out into the deep and fish on the other side of the boat. What does he know about fishing? He made the sea

and all the fish; he knows what school they are in and what it takes to catch them.

Empty fishing boats spell tragedy for both fishermen and the hungry. Never before in the history of the church have we been better trained and equipped and had more authorities on all kinds of issues, than we do today, but I am wondering if we are really seizing the opportunities that are available to us? Empty boats mean something is wrong! Could it be that God is looking to raise up someone who has less training but more impetus to obey? Church God is not looking to your ability, he is looking for obedience. He doesn't need someone to find the fish, he is looking for someone to fish when and where he says! If you fish when and where he tells you to you are sure to fill up the boat he has provided! Isaiah 55:11 **"So shall my word be that goeth forth out of my mouth: it shall not return unto me void, but it shall accomplish that which I please, and it shall prosper in the thing whereto I sent it."**

When corrective measures are taken the boat always fills up. Some of the best church growth material on the market today is found in the next two verses: Luke 5:6-7 **"And when they had this done, they enclosed a great multitude of fishes: and their net brake. 7 And they beckoned unto *their* partners, which were in the other ship, that they should come and help them. And they came, and filled both the ships, so that they began to sink."** Notice there is no argument here over what fish belongs in what boat; there were enough fish and more to fill all the boats! The reason denominational lines have been drawn so tightly is not as much an attempt to protect doctrinal authenticity as to keep fish in the proper fish farm! When the church is doing what it is supposed to, fishing, its primary source of growth will no longer be transfer growth, but a fresh catch! The objective of the captain of this old ship of Zion is a fresh catch, not rearranging fish from aquarium to aquarium!

If you think of the church in the context of being a ship, you quickly realize that it will either become a sea-going vessel of industry and warfare, or a vessel of relaxation and pleasure. According to scripture, as a church we are to be a sea-going vessel of industry and warfare!

There is much discussion in our day about what the church is, or who makes up the church. Let's define the church, and in so doing we will discover what it is, and what it is not;

- Some people believe the building they attend is the church! The religiosity of the Old Testament church structure defined the church as such. Jesus addresses this very subject with the woman at the well John 4:21-24
“Jesus saith unto her, Woman, believe me, the hour cometh, when ye shall neither in this mountain, nor yet at Jerusalem, worship the Father. 22 Ye worship ye know not what: we know what we worship: for salvation is of the Jews. 23 But the hour cometh, and now is, when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth: for the Father seeketh such to worship him. 24 God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth.”
- Some people believe their particular denomination is the church. While there will be people in heaven from all denominations who preach salvation through the Blood of Jesus, no one denomination has a corner on the market. (Assemblies of God – Not enough to serve breakfast to, let alone the marriage supper of the Lamb!)
- Some give deep theological definitions of the church. They say it is the “Ekklesia” (Gr. Called out ones) of God, and it is, but it is so much more than. Paul gives a definition of the church in Ephesians 2:19-22 **“Now therefore ye are no more strangers and foreigners, but fellowcitizens with the saints, and of the**

household of God; 20 And are built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Jesus Christ himself being the chief corner stone; 21 In whom all the building fitly framed together groweth unto an holy temple in the Lord: 22 In whom ye also are builded together for an habitation of God through the Spirit.”

- The best definition I have ever heard given of the church is that it is “an **embassy** in an alien culture, and we are its **ambassadors**”. 2 Corinthians 5:19-20 **“To wit, that God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them; and hath committed unto us the word of reconciliation. 20 Now then we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God did beseech *you* by us: we pray *you* in Christ’s stead, be ye reconciled to God.”** An ambassador is the highest ranking diplomatic representative from one country to another. An embassy is the official residence or offices of an ambassador. As a United States citizen, if you are in a hostile alien culture and you encounter problems, if you can make it to the United States embassy in that country you can find shelter, safety, aid, and hope! That is precisely what the church is supposed to be in the world.

I am very much aware that every born again believer is a habitation of God through the spirit, and as such is a part of the church militant until we form the church triumphant. I also know that my body is the temple of the Holy Ghost.

The church is more than a sanctified Kiwanis club, religious Rotary club, moose lodge, or a holy VFW club! The real church does more than meet three times a week, hold hands and sing “Cum by Yah my Lord”. There’s more to it than owning some property, a building, a van, and an “adopt a highway” sign.

Excuse me, while I remind us that we are not another social club attempting to find our niche in the market, we are an embassy in an alien culture! We are not like everybody else, we are different; we are citizens of another world; we march to the beat of a different drummer; we're pilgrims and strangers; we're a holy nation; we're a chosen generation; we're a royal priesthood; we are looking for a city that has foundations, whose builder and maker is God! Let me set all of the greater Houston area on alert we are not planning on going alone!!!

Let me tell you about the church, I am for the church. I am a product of the church. Because of what the church has helped to accomplish in my life I will gladly be the first to champion its cause and defend its honor! I believe the church to be the greatest organization to have ever been **founded** on this planet!

David loved the church: Psalm 27:4 “**One *thing* have I desired of the LORD, that will I seek after; that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to behold the beauty of the LORD, and to enquire in his temple.**”

Psalm 84:10 “**For a day in thy courts *is* better than a thousand. I had rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God, than to dwell in the tents of wickedness.**”

Psalm 122:1 “**I was glad when they said unto me Let us go into the house of the LORD.**”

Psalm 23:6 “**Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life: and I will dwell in the house of the LORD for ever.**”

For centuries the church has been attacked by Godless tyrants, kings, emperors, dictators, presidents and heads of state. The god of this world has incited his henchmen to kill its members, burn its buildings, ridicule its rituals, mock its methods, seize its

assets, persecute its preachers, martyr its heroes, defy its doctrines, and keep its book from their land. But the church of Jesus Christ continues to gather momentum as its finest hour approaches!

The world doesn't seem to understand the madness behind the method; Jesus set a law into motion when he spoke to Simon Peter regarding the architectural plan for the church on planet earth. Matthew 16:13-19 **"When Jesus came into the coasts of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, saying, *whom do men say that I the Son of man am?* 14 And they said, some say that thou art John the Baptist: some, Elias; and others, Jeremias, or one of the prophets. 15 He saith unto them, *But whom say ye that I am?* 16 And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God. 17 And Jesus answered and said unto him, *Blessed art thou, Simon Barjona: for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father which is in heaven. 18 And I say also unto thee, that thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church; and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. 19 And I will give unto thee the keys of the kingdom of heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven.*"** Some people think the church is built on Simon Peter but the very name Peter is petros and means a piece of a rock or a little rock. No wise builder builds anything on a little rock.

Jesus said **"Upon this rock I will build my church..."** The Greek word for rock here is Petra and means a mass of a rock or a huge immoveable stone! What is the rock upon which the church is built? The confession **"Thou art the Christ the son of the living God"**.

Lets look again at what Paul had to say about the church, Ephesians 2:19-22 “**Now therefore ye are no more strangers and foreigners, but fellow citizens with the saints, and of the household of God; 20 And are built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Jesus Christ himself being the chief corner stone; 21 In whom all the building fitly framed together groweth unto an holy temple in the Lord: 22 In whom ye also are builded together for an habitation of God through the Spirit.**” While Jesus is the foundation upon which the church is built, you and I are an important part of that spiritual building as well.

The enemies of the church don’t seem to get the drift: the more you persecute it; sensor it; stifle it; pressure it; ignore it, the more it grows and thrives!

The ***law*** that Jesus set in motion is the ***law*** of “**NO MATTER WHAT HAPPENS I WILL BUILD MY CHURCH**”! And build it he ***has***, he ***is***, and he ***will***!!! In the spring of 1914 300 people gathered at an opera house in Hot Springs, Arkansas and formed what would become known as the Assemblies of God. There is no way anyone in that meeting could have known what would happen as a result of their desire to seek God and come together for the purpose of doctrinal unity and world evangelization; from that small group of 300 God has built his church until the Assemblies of God now numbers 1,506,834 in the United States, and more than 37,000,000 world wide.

There have been some flagship churches among us who have committed themselves to being sea-going vessels of industry and warfare;

Full Gospel Church in Seoul South Korea - over 750,000 members.

Phoenix 1st Assembly, Phoenix Arizona over 10,000 strong – an outreach center and church plant of several thousand in Los Angeles California.

Evangel World Prayer Center, Louisville Kentucky – over 4,300 in attendance.

Mount Hope Church – Lansing Michigan – more than 4,000 in attendance.

James River Assembly of God, Ozark Missouri – almost 3,700 in attendance. Ozark is a small town of 10,000 just outside of Springfield Missouri. The entire county only has a population of 50,000.

Do you know what separates these great churches from all the others? They have learned when and where to fish! They have decided to become a church of industry and spiritual warfare, rather than be a cruise-liner of relaxation and pleasure. Thank God for them, they have set the example and led the way! We need to follow their example!

Far too many churches have been satisfied to become vessels of relaxation and pleasure! I pose the question to you today, will you allow this church to be a vessel of relaxation and pleasure, or will you use your influence and energy to see it transformed into a sea-going vessel of industry and warfare?

The church, often referred to as the old ship of Zion, in its original state resembles a battleship poised in a state of readiness. Prepared and ready to attack hells strongholds, and its very gates if necessary. The church is supposed to be in a state of readiness at all times. There are those who would like to renovate this old ship of Zion. If they have their way they would:

- Retire its battle gear.

- **Sell** its weapons for scrap metal.
- **Paint** its exterior so that it is more appealing to the public.
- **Rework** its interior to become more relaxing and laid back.

I am certainly not against refining our methods, after all the Guns of yesterday are obsolete. There was a day when it was necessary to manually calculate the course and strategy of a battleship, now it is done by modern means of computer, laser, and radar. The church must adapt its methods to capture its culture, but it must remain a battleship, and never become a cruise ship!

For the next few weeks I want us to look at the differences between a battleship and a cruise ship;

I. A BATTLESHIP FIGHTS FOR, DEFENDS, AND HONORS ONE FLAG! A CRUISE-SHIP FLIES MULTIPLE FLAGS IN ALLEGIANCE TO ALL!

A. You do not see a battleship flying *several* flags; it flies *one* flag, the flag of the country that owns it and commissioned it! We have been bought with a price. Isaiah 43:10-11 (NKJV)
“You *are* My witnesses, says the LORD, and My servant whom I have chosen, that you may know and believe Me, and understand that I *am* He. Before Me there was no God formed, nor shall there be after Me. 11 I, *even* I, *am* the LORD, and besides Me *there is* no savior.”

Isaiah 44:6 (NKJV) **“Thus says the LORD, the King of Israel, And his Redeemer, the LORD of hosts: I *am* the First and I *am* the Last; Besides Me *there is* no God.”**

Isaiah 45:18 (NKJV) **“Thus says the LORD, Who created the heavens, Who is God, Who formed the earth and made it, Who has established it, Who did not create it in vain, Who**

formed it to be inhabited: I *am* the LORD, and *there is* no other.”

Deuteronomy 6:4-5 (NKJV) “Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD *is* one! 5 You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your strength.”

I think we have adequately established who owns the ship, now I want us to look at how He purchased it! 1 Peter 1:18-19 (NKJV) “**knowing that you were not redeemed with corruptible things, like silver or gold, from your aimless conduct received by tradition from your fathers,19 but with the precious blood of Christ, as of a lamb without blemish and without spot.**”

Not only have we been purchased by His sacrifice we have been commissioned by Him! 2 Corinthians 5:18-20 “**Now all things are of God, who has reconciled us to Himself through Jesus Christ, and has given us the ministry of reconciliation,19 that is, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not imputing their trespasses to them, and has committed to us the word of reconciliation.20 Now then, we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God were pleading through us: we implore you on Christ’s behalf, be reconciled to God.” The church must be in solidarity about the flag that it flies.**

When we fully understand the price of our purchase, and the power behind our commission it is literally impossible for us to fly more than one flag!

If the church becomes a battleship it will be:

- Ample, articulate, ambulatory, abnormal, an antidepressant for those who sail on it! It will be ready to meet a need for anyone, at any place and at any time!
- It will be balanced, benevolent, beholding to only one Lord! It will batter the kingdom of darkness, and booby trap the devil! It will have a baptistery that actually gets used for something besides storage! It will believe the Word of God. Be baptized in the Holy Ghost! It will blossom like a rose, and have a clear view of Beulah Land!
- It will be called, capable, calculated, committed, compassionate, consecrated, cooperative, competent, consistent, conquering, creative, colossal, charismatic, and will capitalize on the mistakes of the devil! It will have conviction in its singing, preaching, and praying! No matter how much mud is slung in its direction it will never cease!
- It will be determined, devoted, developed, distinctive, diverse, distinguished, and dawn a different dialect! It will disturb those who are at ease in Zion, drive demons delirious, doom the devil, and will one day dock safely at home!

B. A cruise-ship flies multiple flags in allegiance to all! There is a train of thought afoot in the modern day church that say's the church should soften its message, dilute its methods, and conform to its culture. After all Paul the Apostle said, 1 Corinthians 9:22 **"To the weak I became as weak, that I might win the weak. I have become all things to all *men* that I might by all means save some."** Paul is not speaking of his conformity to the world here; he is speaking of his willingness to become servant of all.

The trend in the church of this hour is to make the church so much like the world, that the world can feel comfortable being a

part of the church, without having to change their lifestyle. In fact, I have watched in horror as governmental and spiritual leaders have paraded across our television sets and stated that there is more than one God that we can look to in a time of national crisis, such as September eleventh 2001. The really tragic thing is that it has not even ruffled the feathers of those who are riding Fun-Lines, relaxing and drinking deeply of pleasure!

But for those of us who are on this old battleship called the old ship of Zion, it has stirred us to attention and activity! We hear it as a battle-cry, not in the sense of bombing an abortion clinic, or taking to the streets in protest, but in having a new zeal to win souls! I want to serve notice on the devil; you have roused from a deep sleep a militant group of salvation sailors who will engage you! They will have fire in their eyes, and a sword in their hand! They have the guts, grit, gall, and backbone to get the job done! We will not sit down, shut up, give up, or cave in! We will win and we will not go quietly or empty handed! This is not a cruise ship this is a battleship!

The church has become so worldly, and the world has become so churchy that there is little distinction between the two. I am not advocating that we set ourselves up to be held in supremacy, but that we live so that the world will know that there is a better way!

If the church is a cruise ship:

- It will not be abiding in the vine! It does not activate its gifts! It is active but not fruitful! It advances its own agenda while ignoring its true purpose! It is accessible but not eternally successful! It may be abreast of the latest trends, but new converts will be absent! It will hold people at arms length while pretending to embrace

them! It will eventually be called into account by God Almighty!

- It will be backslidden, bizarre, blind, and always bemoaning its troubles! It will sidestep its beliefs, will bend and finally break! It will have money like a bank, and will balk when it is asked to reach out!
- It will be calloused, careless, comfortable, contented, and confined within its four walls! It will be comatose and will cater to a carnal crowd! It will be ceremonial, full of calamity, and will cannibalize anyone who dares to raise caution about its direction! It will collapse and eventually cease!
- It will be dead, dull, dry, and eventually will be written off as decease! It is defiled, divided, distracted, decrepit, and depresses everyone it touches! It is deformed, demoralized, dirty, and in a state of decline! It is in a state of denial, has a depth deficiency, and is derelict in its duties! It depends on detours to distract its adherents from their real purpose, and it aids and abets those who have chosen to dodge the draft in the army of God!

C. We have a choice to make; are we going to be a battleship or a cruise ship? Are you interested in fun in the sun, or willing to man a gun? Are you content to wear a Hawaiian lei around your neck, or are you willing to carry a cross? Are you living to drink another cool one, or do you want to drink of a well that will quench your thirst forever? Do you want to hold hands with a one armed bandit, or put your hand in the hand of the man from Galilee?

I can't make your decision for you; I have to decide for myself!

II. A BATTLESHIP IS ALWAYS IN A STATE OF ALERTNESS AND LABOR! A CRUISESHIP IS IN A CONSTANT STATE OF RELAXATION AND REST!

A. Those that inhabit a battleship are constantly alert to what is going on around them. They sleep with one eye open, not to keep from hurting themselves, but to constantly be aware of where the enemy is at and what he is doing. In the case of a battleship it would be a rarity indeed to catch the occupants off guard. The reason it would be almost impossible to catch them off guard is because they understand what is at stake. It can be the difference between winning and losing; freedom and slavery; life and death; heaven and hell!

It is imperative that those of us on board the old ship of Zion live in a state of being on red alert! 1 Peter 5:8 (Living Bible) **“Be careful—watch out for attacks from Satan, your great enemy. He prowls around like a hungry, roaring lion, looking for some victim to tear apart. ⁹Stand firm when he attacks. Trust the Lord; and remember that other Christians all around the world are going through these sufferings too.”** Pearl Harbor is a good example of what can happen when the military is caught off guard! On December 7, 1941 the Japanese attacked the U.S. fleet in Pearl Harbor thus beginning what we know as World War II. (Show Pearl Harbor movie clip)

Just because you are in a state of high alert does not necessarily mean the enemy will not attack! The greatest military minds of World War II never dreamed the Japanese military would dare fly such a risky mission on Pearl Harbor. The Japanese on the other hand were banking on the element of surprise to give them an edge that would end in victory. Let me tell you this old ship of Zion has many enemies that are willing to use any leverage they have to turn their defeat into victory! The devil never plays by the rules!

When Nehemiah returned to Jerusalem to rebuild the walls that had fallen prey to war and weather, he was greeted in part by people who were willing to assist in the effort of restoration; he was also greeted by enemies who wanted to see him fail. (Two things people will never forgive you for; failure; defeat.) They wanted to see him fail so badly that they began to make fun of the work on the walls, and actually threaten progress. Nehemiah attracts two such enemies : Nehemiah 2:10(NKJV) **“When Sanballat the Horonite and Tobiah the Ammonite official heard of it, they were deeply disturbed that a man had come to seek the well-being of the children of Israel.”**

Look at how they attempt to interfere with the work of God. Nehemiah 4:1-3 (NKJV) **“But it so happened, when Sanballat heard that we were rebuilding the wall, that he was furious and very indignant, and mocked the Jews.2 And he spoke before his brethren and the army of Samaria, and said, ‘What are these feeble Jews doing? Will they fortify themselves? Will they offer sacrifices? Will they complete it in a day? Will they revive the stones from the heaps of rubbish—stones that are burned?’3 Now Tobiah the Ammonite was beside him, and he said, ‘whatever they build, if even a fox goes up on it, he will break down their stone wall’.”**

Notice what Nehemiah does next; he does not deny the presence of an enemy; he does not confess the enemy is not there; he prays; prepares; and motivates; stirring the people into a state of readiness for whatever would come next! Nehemiah 4:6 (NKJV) **“So we built the wall and the entire wall was joined together up to half its height, for the people had a mind to work.”** No battle can be won unless and until the people are stirred to action and activity! There is no place on this battleship for deadbeats, only soldiers who are committed to the cause! Anything less than one hundred percent dedication is dead

weight! Did you get on this ship to relax or fight the good fight of faith?

The battle does not end there; it never does! (NKJV) Nehemiah 4:7-8 **“Now it happened, when Sanballat, Tobiah, the Arabs, the Ammonites, and the Ashdodites heard that the walls of Jerusalem were being restored and the gaps were beginning to be closed, that they became very angry,⁸ and all of them conspired together to come *and* attack Jerusalem and create confusion.”** Nothing on this planet brings people together like an attack on this old gospel ship! It will rally the opposition like nothing else will! Remember, the opposition started with Sanballat and Tobiah, now it also includes the Arabs, the Ammonites, and the Ashdodites. (Consider the crowd at a business meeting when something is controversial! Dead people have attended!)

It will also rally the troops! Nehemiah 4:16-18 **“So it was, from that time on, *that half of my servants worked at construction, while the other half held the spears, the shields, the bows, and wore armor; and the leaders were behind all the house of Judah.***¹⁷ Those who built on the wall, and those who carried burdens, loaded themselves so that **with one hand they worked at construction, and with the other held a weapon.**¹⁸ **Every one of the builders had his sword girded at his side as he built.”** When those who sail on the old ship of Zion realize what their voyage is about; where they fit into the scheme of things; and feel they are qualified to assist in the overall effort the battle will be won right away! Romans 16:20 **“And the God of peace will crush Satan under your feet shortly. The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you. Amen.”**

The enemy doesn't stand a chance; he's defeated before he starts! The wall is finished in chapter **seven**! The project was

completed; the war was won in spite of Sanballat, Tobiah, or any other loud mouthed enemy!

The inhabitants of a battleship are not on a sightseeing tour, they are there to work together to accomplish a mission! Because of this every person understands they must pull their share of the load, and carry their part of the responsibility!

If the church is a battleship;

- It will be embattled, eager, elect, earnest, established on The Rock Jesus Christ!
- It will be, enlightened, energized, efficient, elevated, and its prayers will be effectual!
- It will be, empowered, endowed, expectant, and ecstatic about the future!
- It will have a great capacity for elasticity!
- It will embalm spiritually dead corpses with a solution that will cause them to immediately spring back to life!
- It will allow the embers of the Holy Spirit to start a fire that the fire department from hell can't put out!
- It will be the epicenter of the Glory of God in the earth!
- It will stand on the edge of eternity and take the hand of lost humankind with one hand and God Almighty with the other hand and bring them together!
- It will be the embassy of heaven in an alien culture!
- One day it will eject from this sphere to go sweeping through the pearly gates!

- It will be fair, factual, and faithful in all it sets its hand to do!
- It will be free of all restrictions, fundamental in its doctrines, and family oriented in its practices!
- It will be fervent in its works and prayers!
- It will be full-fledged in its worship of God!
- It will be futuristic in its vision!
- It will be farsighted, far-flung, full of faith, and filled with fellowship!
- It will be fully furnished for good works!
- It will be gentle, generous, and genuine!
- It will be glad, grateful, going, growing, goal oriented, and grandiose!
- It will get the garbage out and keep it out!
- It will gather golden grain for the glory of God!
- It will gain the prize at the end of the race!

Aren't you glad you are a sailor on this old ship of Zion? I'd rather be an old time Christian than any thing I know!

B. A cruise-ship is in a constant state of rest and relaxation! The activity of the clientele on this kind of sea going vessel is eat, sleep, relax, and get motivated to do it all over again! Proverbs 6:10-11(NKJV) **“A little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to sleep. 11So shall your poverty come on you like a prowler and your need like an armed man.”** A cruise-ship is the vehicle of choice for draft dodgers and lazy people!

Proverbs 24:30-34 (NKJV) **“I went by the field of the lazy *man*, and by the vineyard of the man devoid of understanding; ³¹and there it was, all overgrown with thorns; its surface was covered with nettles; its stone wall was broken down. ³²When I saw *it*, I considered it well; I looked on it and received instruction: ³³A little sleep, a little slumber, A little folding of the hands to rest; ³⁴So shall your poverty come *like* a prowler, And your need like an armed man.”**

If the church becomes a cruise ship;

- It will be empty, egotistical, and eccentric!
- It will be encumbered in its work, walk, and will!
- It will be unduly exposed to the devil!
- It will be extreme, exclusive, and will endorse an intoxicated lifestyle!
- Revival will elude its premises, it will be excessive, and will embark on an endless journey to nowhere!
- It will be embarrassed to be named among the invisible church, will be ruled by the traditions of the elders, and will try to build its own empire in the here and now!
- It will impose an embargo on sending people into the ministry!
- It will be fashionable, far-fetched, frivolous, fretful, and far-gone!
- It will be frustrated, and fussy!
- It will be full of factions, failure, and fatalism!
- It will be generic, glamorous, gluttonous, and groggy!
- It will be guilty, grim and gloomy!
- It will always be in need of a gimmick, and the Christian life becomes nothing more than a game!

Those of you who are bent on riding a cruise-liner of rest and relaxation; I have some strong Biblical advice for you; Proverbs 6:6-9(NKJV) “Go to the ant, you sluggard! Consider her ways and be wise, ⁷Which, having no captain, Overseer or ruler, ⁸Provides her supplies in the summer, *and* gathers her food in the harvest. ⁹How long will you slumber, O sluggard? When will you rise from your sleep?”

C. I am concluding with the following questions:

- Are you willing to sleep on a military cot or do you need a state room?
- Can you take orders or would you rather stroll leisurely across the deck and admire the beauty of the trip?
- Must you have all kinds of designer clothes or is a military uniform good enough?
- Will you be content to rest in the lap of luxury or will you stir yourself to activity, industry and warfare?

III. THE INHABITANTS OF A BATTLESHIP ARE CALLED SOLDIERS! THE INHABITANTS OF A CRUISESHIP ARE CALLED CUSTOMERS!

A. Webster say's a soldier is; a member of an army; a person of much military experience; a person who works for a specified cause.

When I hear the word soldier it suggests; the person knows where they are going and what they are doing; the person is extremely disciplined; the person is brave; the person is well trained; the person is physically capable of finishing the task.

Those who sail on this old ship of Zion have enlisted in the army of God. We have committed to the cause of Christ! We have burned the bridges of retreat behind us! We have severed all other options! We are committed to the war against sin if it costs us our lives; that my friend is the attitude of a real soldier! Anyone can wear the uniform, have the haircut, and shine their shoes, but I ask, who will be willing to lay it all down for the cause of Christ? Those that are real soldiers have put their own personal interests on the back burner for a higher and nobler cause!

(Vines) In the New Testament as a noun the word soldier is used in the natural sense six times in John; thirteen times in Acts; and is not used again in the New Testament. It is used metaphorically of one who endures hardship in the cause of Christ in 2 Timothy 2:1-4 (NKJV) **“You therefore, my son, be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus.2 And the things that you have heard from me among many witnesses, commit these to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.3 You therefore must endure hardship as a good soldier of Jesus Christ.4 No one engaged in warfare entangles himself with the affairs of *this* life, that he may please him who enlisted him as a soldier.”** This passage of scripture details a number of things about a soldier:

- Verse three let's us know that soldiers must endure hardships. No one ever said it would be easy. In Ephesians 6:12 (NKJV) we are told, **“We do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this age, against spiritual *hosts* of wickedness in the heavenly *places*.”** This is four classifications of demonic forces that are at work in our world, fighting against the soldiers aboard the old ship of Zion.
- Verse four let's know that those who have chosen to become a soldier do not unnecessarily entangle

themselves with the things of this life so that they can concentrate on pleasing the commander in chief! In fact Paul say's to Timothy in 1 Timothy 1:18-19 (NKJV)

“This charge I commit to you, son Timothy, according to the prophecies previously made concerning you, that by them you may wage the good warfare,¹⁹ having faith and a good conscience, which some having rejected, concerning the faith have suffered shipwreck.” Paul continues to challenge Timothy concerning his tour of duty as a soldier in 1 Timothy 6:11-12 (NKJV) **“But you, O man of God, flee these things and pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, patience, gentleness.¹² Fight the good fight of faith, lay hold on eternal life, to which you were also called and have confessed the good confession in the presence of many witnesses.”**

- In addition, if we are soldiers in the army of God and engaged in fighting a real enemy we need armor for protection, and weapons for both offense and defense. Ephesians 6:10-17 (NKJV) **“Finally, my brethren, be strong in the Lord and in the power of His might.¹¹ Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil.¹² For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this age, against spiritual *hosts* of wickedness in the heavenly *places*.¹³ Therefore take up the whole armor of God, that you may be able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand.¹⁴ Stand therefore, having girded your waist with truth, having put on the breastplate of righteousness,¹⁵ and having shod your feet with the preparation of the gospel of peace;¹⁶ above all, taking the shield of faith with which you will be able to quench all the fiery darts of the wicked one.¹⁷ And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God.”**

Our weapons are not average or normal; they are *state-of-the-art*! 2 Corinthians 10:3-6 (NKJV) **“For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war according to the flesh.⁴ For the weapons of our warfare *are* not carnal but mighty in God for pulling down strongholds, ⁵ casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ, ⁶ and being ready to punish all disobedience when your obedience is fulfilled.”**

Please understand we are not a bunch of weak willed ill equipped vigilantes attempting to hold the fort until we are rescued! We have the most up to date weapons available; the best defense possible; the most superior training on the planet; and our minds are made up to accomplish our purpose for being in this army! WE ARE SOLDIERS!

Because this old ship of Zion is a battleship;

- It is healthy, hearty, and extremely honorable!
- It is happy, hyper, holy, harmless, and walks together in perfect harmony!
- It is heroic, hot, hated and heterosexual!
- It is the habitation of God and homesteaded on the grounds of holiness!
- It is heir of promises and possessions, too great to be described in this sermon, and possesses hope in a hopeless world!
- It is headed for the heaven John saw coming down from God prepared as a bride adorned for her husband!
- It is inspirational, inclusive and increasing day by day!

- It is imitated, indigenous, and itches to insulate its world from judgment to come!
- It is indivisible, indestructible, and baptizes by immersion those who have recently enlisted!
- Its work is immeasurable; it can easily be identified by the illumination that it attempts to interject into the darkness of this present age! It takes its instructions from its commander in chief, the great I AM!
- It is jubilant, joyful, and justified in the sight of God!
- It is knowledgeable, kind and possesses the key to reach a world on its way to hell!
- It is the kiss of life to those who are spiritually dead, and the kiss of peace to those who have been tossed to and fro on the angry sea of life!
- It possesses a kinship with the spirits of just men made perfect!

I don't know about you but I had rather be in the army of God, sailing on this battleship of Zion than to dwell in the palaces of the wicked!

B. A cruise-ship is not occupied by soldiers, it is populated with customers! I want to point out several things about customers:

- Customer's purchase; they rarely invest! They pay their money expecting to receive something in return!
- Customers are all about what is in their best interest; they couldn't care less about the overall good of the establishment!
- Customers believe they are always right; they can rarely admit they were wrong!

- Customers expect to be served hand and foot; a servant's mentality is foreign to them!
- Customers generally have an attitude that says you can't make it without me! With customers, everything revolves around I, me, and mine!

If the church is a cruise-ship;

- It will be halting, hampered and half-hearted!
- It will be haphazard, hamstrung, and hard-hearted!
- It will be hasty, haughty, and hateful!
- It will be hesitant, halting and handicapped!
- It will be hurt, hysterical, hung up on heresies, and will hobble through life holding to a crutch of worldliness!
- It will have more hang-ups than hand-bells, and will believe that homosexual tendencies will result in an alternate lifestyle that God will place His stamp of approval on!
- It will be imbalanced, immobile, and indifferent to the real needs of its culture!
- It will be indulgent, intoxicated, incompetent, and impotent!
- It will be juvenile, lack judgment, and live continuously under a juniper tree!
- It will get its exercise by jumping to conclusions; and will be a joke in the eyes of the world!
- It will be the kiss of death to its adherents; and be known for its love of the practices of the world!

Far too many people in the church of this modern day have a customer mentality, and expect an easy listening gospel that keeps them from feeling badly about their sin and lack of involvement in the things of God! Far too many preachers are preaching sermon-ettes to Christian-ettes, having a little talk with Jesus, and telling everybody everything is alright; when its not!

C. Are you content to be a customer or do you want to join the army of God as a soldier and ride with, and fight alongside the crew of this old ship of Zion until it docks safe at home?

Do you want to?

- Purchase or invest?
- Give or receive?
- Do you want to focus on what's best for you or what's best for the Kingdom?
- Do you always have to be right or are you willing to repent and return?
- Are you going to spend your life waiting on someone to serve you, or develop an insatiable desire to serve the King and Kingdom wherever you can?
- Is everything going to have to revolve around you, your four and no more, or can you lay down your need to be Mr. Wonderful long enough to see that there is a war to fight and win?

In closing, I ask; are you going to be a soldier or a customer?

IV. THE CAPTAIN (PASTOR) OF A BATTLESHIP TAKES ORDERS FROM A HIGHER AUTHORITY! THE CAPTAIN OF A CRUISESHIP ANSWERS TO THE INVESTORS!

A. Webster's dictionary says a U.S. navy captain is an officer ranking higher than a commander; he is the commander of a ship. All battleships have soldiers or sailors, they will have any number of people who are assigned to various responsibilities, but a captain is a person who has ultimate responsibility with regard to a sea-going vessel. The responsibility of the captain of a battleship is an extremely weighty responsibility.

The responsibilities of a battleship captain include but are not limited to;

- Fulfilling its purpose - making sure the wishes of the Commander In Chief are being carried out at all times
- Oversight of personnel - being responsible for the well being of everyone aboard his vessel
- Proper navigation - making sure the ship is on course at all times
- Strategic timing – making sure the ship is where it is supposed to be, when it is supposed to be, doing what it is supposed to do
- Returning intact – attempting to minimize loss of life & sparing the loss of equipment

A captain of a battleship has grave responsibilities that stay with him twenty-four hours a day!

The Lord is the head of the church; he is the captain of our salvation. Ephesians 5:23 ***“For the husband is the head of the wife, even as Christ is the head of the church: and he is the savior of the body.”*** Ephesians 1:22-23 declares that God ***“hath put all things under his feet, and gave him to be the head over all things to the church, 23 which is his body, the fullness of him that filleth all in all.”***

The Pastor (captain) also assumes grave responsibilities; his responsibilities stay with him twenty-four hours a day! Acts 20:28 ***“Take heed therefore unto yourselves, and to all the flock, over which the Holy Ghost hath made you overseers, to feed the church of God, which he hath purchased with his own blood.”*** 1 Peter 5:2 ***“Feed the flock of God which is among you, taking the oversight thereof, not by constraint, but willingly; not for filthy lucre, but of a ready mind.”*** These two Scriptures point out several things that we would do well to underscore:

- The Holy Ghost appoints leaders. ***“Take heed therefore unto yourselves, and to all the flock, over which the Holy Ghost hath made you overseers...”*** A true Pastor (Captain) is not elected by a vote of the people, he is appointed by the Commander-In-Chief; it is a cabinet position!
- The Pastor (Captain) is in charge of personnel. ***“the Holy Ghost hath made you overseers...”*** The word overseer comes from the Greek word Episkopos (ep-is'-kop-os), meaning a superintendent, or an officer in charge.
- The Pastor (Captain) is charged with the responsibility of making sure the Church is fulfilling its purpose; carrying out the desires of the Commander-In-Chief. ***“Feed the flock of God which is among you...”*** The Greek word for feed is Poimaino (Poy-mah'-ee-no), and means to tend as a shepherd would tend his sheep.

Notice; the sheep do not belong to the shepherd, they belong to God!

- The Pastor is to take the oversight. ***“Feed the flock of God which is among you, taking the oversight thereof...”*** Notice the Pastor (Captain) is to ***“take”*** the oversight; he is not to sit around and wait for someone to give it to him. He is to be diligent to lead the way. The word oversight comes from the Greek word Episkopeo (ep-ee-skop-eh’-o), meaning to take oversight; implying to beware or proceeding with caution.
- The Pastor is to give a freewill offering of leadership; ***“not by constraint, but willingly; not for filthy lucre, but of a ready mind.”*** He is to do this not because we feel forced to do so, but because it is in our heart to do it (Pastor who said he hated pastoring); not for a paycheck but because our heart compels us.
- There will be a reward for those who have willingly assumed such great responsibility. 2 Timothy 4:6-8 ***“For I am now ready to be offered, and the time of my departure is at hand. 7 I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith: 8 Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing.”***

If this Church is a battleship, and the leaders fulfill their responsibility;

- It will be loving, legitimate, lasting, loyal, and sometimes be labeled as lunatics!
- It will be laboring for the Lord who has loved it, believing in the laying on of hands, and learning the language of a land that is fairer than day!

- It will be launching laymen into ministry, lightening the load of the heavy laden, and becoming a life support system for those who have already been counted out!
- It will be marked, maligned, and misused!
- It will be mighty, magnanimous, magnificent, magnetic, motivated, merciful, and meritorious!
- It will be militant, multiplying, matter-of-fact, having a made-up-mind, marveling at miracles, and moving in the manifestations of the spirit!
- It will be ministering a message that is relevant, marching to the beat of a different drummer, and making the devil so mad he can't see straight!
- It will be nice, noble, and sometimes noisy!
- It will be neutralizing the nature of sin, negating the nights in the lives of its adherents, and nailed to the cross of self sacrifice!
- It will be orderly organized, and opportunistic!
- It will be fully outfitted, full of options, and providing opportunities for the underprivileged!
- It will be on target, offering opportunities for over comers, and under oath to fulfill the great commission!
- It will be pure, patient, personal, positive, potent, powerful, and productive!
- It will be peaceful, prophetic, Pentecostal, and a pacesetter in all areas of spiritual life!
- It will provide a panorama of paradise, be pregnant with a passion for souls, poised to preach the promises of God and the perils of pretentious living, and will propel its patrons through the pearly gates!

I don't know about you but I have my mind made up to ride a battleship all the way home!

B. The Captain of a cruise ship answers to his investors. His investors operate from the ideology that says;

- I bought this ship it belongs to me!
- I expect to be in charge, give the orders, and the orders must be carried out!
- The Captain will make a profit or be replaced!

The Pastor (Captain) of a cruise ship is asked to operate in the following ways;

- He does not answer to God; he answers to the people who bought and paid for the Church! (Experience with lady who said "O yes this is my Church...")
- He must please certain people in order to keep his job! The Apostle John speaks of this in his Epistle. 3 John 9-11 ***"I sent a brief letter to the church about this, but proud Diotrephes, who loves to push himself forward as the leader of the Christians there, does not admit my authority over him and refuses to listen to me. 10 When I come I will tell you some of the things he is doing and what wicked things he is saying about me and what insulting language he is using. He not only refuses to welcome the missionary travelers himself but tells others not to, and when they do he tries to put them out of the church. 11 Dear friends, don't let this bad example influence you. Follow only what is good. Remember that those who do what is right prove that they are God's children; and those who continue in evil prove that they are far from God."*** (Living Bible)

- The Pastor (Captain) will be expected to take orders from the investors; grow the Church; and build a bank account. All these things must be done while not changing a thing! All things must remain as they were from the beginning! If he cannot grow the church without changing things he will be replaced! (Deacon who said preachers are a-dime-a-dozen) (Man who called about the music – I told him that if I would do what he wanted me to we would sing “I come to the garden alone” every Sunday, and if we did that is exactly where we would be, in the garden alone!)

If the ship you are riding is a cruise ship;

- It will be lazy, liberal, lustful, limited, in love with leisure, and constantly in limbo!
- It will be counted among the living dead, lapsing into lethargy, large in their own eyes but little in Gods eyes!
- It will be modern, mainstream, manipulative, marginal, and mercenary!
- It will be melancholy, misled, mixed up, mincing words, always marching on middle ground, mimicking a morgue, and masquerading as the true Church! (If you like thick curtains, dim lights, and soft music you don't need a Church you need a funeral home!)
- It will be napping, negligent, needy, nervous, neutral, and always nagging about nothing!
- It will be obtuse, obsessive, obstinate, opinionated, and ostentatious!
- It will be out-manned, out-gunned- out-smarted, overcharged with surfeiting, out of Gods will, and fulfilling the great omission!

- It will be popular, political, proud, perverse, permissive, provocative, promiscuous, pathetic, and full of poison!
- It will be paganistic, passive, paralyzed, prejudiced, pawns in the hands of the devil, and will be panic stricken on judgment day!

The day will dawn when God will hold the **Church** accountable for its reaction to the lost-ness of the world and the great commission.

C. Let me ask you;

- Do you want to float your own boat or sail and serve on His?
- Do you want to get your way or allow Him to have His way?
- Do you want to have everybody answering to you or are you willing to answer to Him?
- Are you more interested in making a profit or making disciples?

Every Church is either a **battleship** or a **cruise ship**, what do you want this one to be?

V. THE PURPOSE OF A BATTLESHIP IS TO CARRY OUT THE ORDERS OF THE COMMANDER IN CHIEF! THE PURPOSE OF A CRUISE SHIP IS TO MAKE A PROFIT!

A. The purpose of a battleship is a very narrow purpose; carry out the direct orders of the Commander-In-Chief! Every move a battleship makes is to carry out the following orders:

- When it pulls out of port it is for the purpose of; doing what it is commissioned to do; going to a specific location; it's route and destination have been predetermined (it never decides on it's own to take the scenic route so the sailors can enjoy the trip)!
- When it docks it is for the purpose of; doing what it is commissioned to do; maintenance; restocking supplies; refueling; R&R for it's sailors; waiting for it's next assignment!
- When it performs maneuvers; it is doing what it is commissioned to do; it is practicing for the day of battle; it is showing its enemies what it is capable of!
- When it travels to the far reaches of the earth and for months just sits in the middle of the sea it is not in a state of inactivity it is doing what it is commissioned to do; it is presenting a much needed military presence (sometimes just showing up makes all the difference in the world); it is in a state of high alert; it is prepared and ready to respond to direct orders at a moments notice!
- When it engages in battle it is doing what it was commissioned to do; it is carrying out the direct orders of the Commander-In-Chief; it never picks its own fights it fights the battles it has been assigned to fight!

As a battleship the church also assumes grave responsibilities:

- When the church pulls out of port it is for the purpose of; doing what it is commissioned to do; going to a specific location (the world); it's route and destination have been predetermined Mark 16:15 (NKJV) ***“And He said to them, “Go into all the world and preach the***

gospel to every creature.”; this is not about us enjoying the trip it is about fulfilling the Great Commission! (John F. Kennedy once said, “Ask not what your country can do for you, but what you can do for your country.”)

- The church docks three times a week for the purpose of; receiving additional ***training***, and helping to disciple others; refueling; R&R for its sailors; and receiving instructions for the next ***assignment***!
- When the church leaves its dock to perform maneuvers; it is getting ready for the day of ***battle***. Some of the saddest words in Scripture are found in Psalm 78:9 (KJV) ***“The children of Ephraim, being armed and carrying bows, turned back in the day of battle.”*** May that never be said of us; it is showing its enemies what it is capable of. Philippians 4:13 ***“I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.”***
- When the church travels to the far reaches of the earth it does not do so for the purpose of vacationing, but for the purpose of presenting a much needed ***presence*** Isaiah 60:1-3 (NKJV) ***“Arise, shine; For your light has come! And the glory of the LORD is risen upon you. 2 For behold, the darkness shall cover the earth, and deep darkness the people; But the LORD will arise over you and His glory will be seen upon you. 3 The Gentiles shall come to your light, and kings to the brightness of your rising.”*** Sometimes just showing up makes all the difference in the world (there are many churches who do not even show up on the day of battle); it is in a state of high alert, and is prepared and ready to respond to direct orders at a moments notice!
- When the church engages in battle it is doing what it was commissioned to do; it is carrying out the direct orders of the Commander-In-Chief; it never picks its own fights it fights the battles it has been ***assigned*** to fight!

If the church is the battleship it was designed to be;

- It will be quality, qualified, quantitative, and quick to quite all quarrels!
- It will be ransomed, repentant, and reconciled!
- It will be refined, refreshed, rested, and relaxed because it is right!
- It will be respectful, responsive, radiant, and rejoicing!
- It will be radical, revolutionary, resilient, and red hot!
- It will be rooted and grounded in the Word, running the race with patience, raining on the devils parade, and reaping the rewards of the redeemed!
- It will be scrutinized, savvy, sacred, sovereign, and sensible!
- It will be sympathetic, stable, and settled not self-destructive!
- It will be sick of status-quo, see the importance of servant hood, stand up for the cause of Christ, and be actively involved in smashing the kingdom of darkness to smithereens!
- It will be timely, teachable, tuned in, turned around, and trusting in the trinity!
- It will be touched by the hand of God, triumphing in truth and tarrying for Pentecostal power!
- It will be transacting treaties, and terminating the tears of those who are hurting!

Would you rather labor on a battleship or relax on a cruise ship?

B. If the church becomes a cruise ship its purpose is strictly for **profit!** (Presbyter who told the ministerial candidate that the A/G is a non-prophet organization)

The corporations and people who own cruise ships do so with the following things in mind:

- They are attempting to attract customers, not soldiers!
- They design their ships for the comfort of the customers, not for the purpose of warfare!

The reason a cruise ship is outfitted with such elaborate amenities is not for the pleasure or safety of the customer but to attract them for the expressed purpose of turning a profit!

Owners of a cruise ship do not own that vessel because they want to make your life more pleasurable they own it to turn a profit and make their life better!

If the church is a cruise ship;

- It will be Quiet, questionable, quarreling, and constantly in a quandary!
- It will be continuously quenching the moving of the Holy Spirit, conveniently caught in the quagmire of sin, and always of the verge of quitting!
- It will be rotten, rabid, redundant, and repetitious!
- It will be reserved, repulsive, resisting the things of God, always railing against that which is right, and rambling about without reason!
- It will be sarcastic, sad, shallow, and silent on the issues that really matter!

- It will be skeptical, superficial, full of scandals, and constantly scoffing at those who claim to be sanctified!
- It will be slumbering, sick, sinful, preaching a socialized Gospel, and always sidestepping responsibility!
- It will be treacherous, tantalizing, too tolerant, and absolutely toxic!
- It will be tense, temporal, tormented, and tightfisted!
- It will be full of talebearers, tainting theological truths, a threat to its adherents, trading truth for transgression, and will eventually be terminated by GOD Himself!

The time has come for the church to decide whether it wants to fulfill its real purpose for existence or settle for the temporal pleasures of this life. The people who must decide are setting in this room. What will your choice be?

C. I want to ask you some questions:

- Are you intent on being in the perfect center of God's will or do you tend to choose the path of least resistance?
- Do you seek the will of God with a whole heart or do you position yourself in the place that is most advantageous to you personally?
- Do you prepare yourself every day as if this will be the day you face your greatest challenge or are you strolling leisurely through life?
- When the battle is in full array are you at your post of duty or do you take a vacation until the heat has been turned off?

- Are you more concerned with fulfilling the Great Commission or doing something that will temporarily benefit you?

We must all ask ourselves the question, am I going to live my life in a self-serving manner or am I going to fulfill the commission of him who has sent me?

VI. A BATTLESHIP HAS ONE ENEMY! THE ENEMIES OF A CRUISE SHIP ARE ALL ITS COMPETITORS!

A. A battleship is not a friendly cruiser. When a battleship is deployed several things become immediately apparent:

- An enemy has been predetermined!
- A peace keeping mission must be fulfilled!
- Only the enemy will be fired on!
- There will be no retreat until the ship is destroyed, or the battle is won!

The church, as a battleship, has been deployed in this present world of sin and darkness. Matthew 16:18-19 (KJV) “*And I say also unto thee, that thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church; and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. 19 And I will give unto thee the keys of the kingdom of heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven.”*

As a battleship on assignment several things become apparent:

- An enemy has been predetermined! Your spouse, children, employer, pastor, or church is not your enemy! Satan is your enemy! Ephesians 6:12 (KJV) ***“For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places.”*** We are all facing an enemy that has been predetermined and plainly declared! According to the Scripture this enemy; tempted Jesus; caused man to fall from grace; blinds the minds of unbelievers; opposes the righteous; tempts believers to disobey; contends with and slanders the saints; inflicts disease; works hardship on the world; and drags individuals to hell to be eternally separated from the presence of God!
- A peace keeping mission must be fulfilled! We live in a world that strives for a peace that has proven to be very illusive. The battleship called the Church has the answer the world is searching for; true peace can be attained only after coming into right relationship and fellowship with the Prince of Peace! John 14:27 (KJV) ***“Peace I leave with you, my peace I give unto you: not as the world giveth, give I unto you. Let not your heart be troubled, neither let it be afraid.”*** Psalm 119:165 (KJV) ***“Great peace have they which love thy law: and nothing shall offend them.”*** The reason the world cannot reach a peace agreement with their enemies or with themselves is because it can only be attained through Christ! Isaiah 26:3 (KJV) ***“Thou wilt keep him in perfect peace, whose mind is stayed on thee: because he trusteth in thee.”*** John 16:33 (KJV) ***“These things I have spoken unto you, that in me ye might have peace. In the world ye shall have tribulation: but be of good cheer; I have overcome the world.”*** The business of the battleship called the church is to capture the world and introduce them to the giver of true peace! 2 Corinthians 5:17-20 (NKJV) ***“Whoever is in Christ is a new creation: the old things have passed away; behold new things have come.”***¹⁸ ***And all this is from God, who has***

reconciled us to himself through Christ and given us the ministry of reconciliation,¹⁹ namely, God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ, not counting their trespasses against them and entrusting to us the message of reconciliation. ²⁰ So we are ambassadors for Christ, as if God were appealing through us. We implore you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God.”

- Only the enemy will be fired on! Friendly fire is a problem with military operations the world over. This is precipitated by not properly identifying the target before taking action. Saul made David the enemy and the target when the real enemy was pride, rebellion, and arrogance. Paul made John Mark the enemy when the real enemy was lack of dedication and understanding.
- There will be no retreat until the ship is destroyed, or the battle is won! Philippians 3:13-14 (KJV) “Brethren, I count not myself to have apprehended: but *this* one thing *I do*, forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth unto those things which are before, 14 I press toward the mark for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus.” 1 Corinthians 9:24 “Know ye not that they which run in a race run all, but one receives the prize? So run, that ye may obtain.” In the book of Judges Gideon and his 300 men were pursuing the Midianites; notice what the Scripture records of them. Judges 8:4 (KJV) “***And Gideon came to Jordan, and passed over, he, and the three hundred men that were with him, faint, yet pursuing them.***”

If the Church is the battleship God intended it to be:

- It will be unbreakable, unshakeable, undefeated, unparalleled, and under siege most of the time!
- It will be unique, unified, upright, and universal!

- It will be It will umpire ultimatums, underwrite unction, and unveil the unknown!
- It will be vital, valuable, virtuous, and extremely victorious!
- It will be visionary, high voltage, vacating vices, and creating viable vessels!
- It will be wise, whole, awakening the weary, reaching the wretches, and walking the walk!
- It will be weathering the storm, setting high water marks, working for wages, and awaiting a wedding!
- It will be excited, exemplifying a good example, prescribing extra patience, declaring the expense of living for God worthwhile, and introducing ex-sinners to Christ!
- It will be yielding a yoke that is bearable!
- It will be anticipating spiritual Zion, zeroing its people in on proper zeal, and will end with zero gravity!

Would you rather fight the real enemy, or create your own?

C. If the Church becomes a cruise ship its declared enemy will be its competitors! Think of all the religions there are in the world today. The stated reason for this is to protect doctrinal purity, but the real truth is to keep the sheep from jumping too many fences! Phrases like my territory - your territory, my people – your people, are in vogue. As a result a spirit of jealousy has caused the organized Church to see real decreases in overall Church attendance in this country.

When this kind of spirit prevails all competitors become the target or enemy.

When the Church is a cruise ship:

- It will be uncaring, unfeeling, unconcerned, unkind, unwise, and unhappy!
- It will be unwise, unbiblical, unclean, and unaware of the sin that is in it and around it!
- It will attempt to be undercover, and unable to correct the problems of the society it resides in!
- It will be vulnerable, vain, vagrant, vengeful, vicious, and will create a vacuum in the lives its adherents!
- It will be worldly, wasted, watered down, and will waffle on all the issues!
- It will be wild, whipped, living in spiritual wantonness, and eventually be weeping and wailing in outer darkness!
- It will be eccentric, and excommunicated from the invisible Church!
- It will yak about things it does not understand, yawning because of its comatose condition, and yearning for the things of God!
- It will produce a zest for life that is wrongly directed!

C. In closing, I want to ask you a few questions;

- Do you know who your real enemy is?
- Are you bringing peace or chaos into situations in which you are involved?

- Are engaging the *enemy* or the *church* in battle?
- Have you made up your mind to stay with the *battleship* or have you decided to ride a *cruise ship*?